

**Board 1**

West Deals

None Vul

♠ J 8 6 3 2

♥ Q T 8 4

♦ 9 8 3

♣ A

♠ 9

♥ A 9 3

♦ K 5 2

♣ K J T 9 6 2

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ A Q T 5

♥ J 7 6 2

♦ Q J T 7

♣ 5

♠ K 7 4

♥ K 5

♦ A 6 4

♣ Q 8 7 4 3

West

Pass

Pass

All Pass

North

1 ♣

5 ♣

East

Pass

South

3 ♣

5 ♣ by North

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

Is there any doubt? Although you only have 11 HCP your 6-card suit adds 2 more. And with 13 points you should always open. So you open 1 ♣.

Partner responds 3 ♣.

With the ♣ fit your hand is now revalued to 15 points. But it's still a close thing. You may be able to make 5 ♣ or you may not.

Passing would not be horrible - but when in doubt it is usually better to be bold. You cross your fingers and bid 5 ♣.

North plays 5 ♣. East leads the ♦ Q.

**North plays 5 ♣. East leads the ♦ Q.**

The two black Aces aren't going away so if you are to make this contract you must do something about your ♦ loser. And the only likely place to put it is on dummy's ♠ K. If East has the ♠ A, you can lead up to the ♠ K and make a winner out of it.

Suppose you win the ♦ Q in dummy and play a ♣. Somebody will win the ♣ A and play another ♦. You win this and lead toward the ♠ K. No good. East jumps up with his ♠ A and sets you with a ♦ winner.

The problem was that when you played a trump you let the timing go to the defense. They could knock out your last ♦ stopper while they still had the ♠ A. Try it this way.

Win the ♦ in your hand and immediately play the ♠ 9. If East doesn't take his ♠ A he'll never get it, so assume he goes up. Now he leads ♦ J but you win, get to dummy with the ♥ K and play the ♠ K, discarding the ♦ loser.

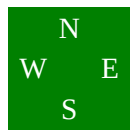
Pulling trumps is very important, but sometimes there is something you must do **BEFORE** you play trumps.

In this hand that something is to establish the ♠ K so you can discard your ♦ loser.

**Board 2**  
North Deals  
N-S Vul

♠ Q J 5  
♥ J 8 7 3  
♦ Q 7 4  
♣ K Q T

♠ K 4 2  
♥ 5 2  
♦ 9 8 3 2  
♣ A 7 6 3



♠ A 6 3  
♥ K Q T 9 6 4  
♦ A K J  
♣ 8

♠ T 9 8 7  
♥ A  
♦ T 6 5  
♣ J 9 5 4 2

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
|          | Pass  | 1♥   | Pass  |
| 3♥       | Pass  | 4NT  | Pass  |
| 5♣       | Pass  | 5♥   |       |
| All Pass |       |      |       |

5♥ by East

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

You have a very good hand. But not good enough to open 2♣, so you open 1♥.

Partner jumps to 3♥.

This is close. Partner has 11 or 12 points and good ♥ support. Your hand revalues to 21 points. You might have a slam. You decide to try for it and bid 4NT. Partner replies 5♣ showing no Aces. So much for the slam. You bid 5♥.

East plays 5♥. South leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, North plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

**East plays 5♥. South leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, North plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.**

You cannot avoid losing either of the two Aces. So therefore you must do something about the ♠ loser. And the only thing you can do with it is to discard it on one of dummy's ♣s.

Be careful. If you lead a trump now a defender will take the Ace and play another ♠, exposing your loser while the ♣A is still out. You must set up the ♣ first. So at trick 2 play your ♣ to dummy's ♣Q. A defender may win this and play a ♠, but you win the ♠Q and play the ♣K, discarding your ♠ loser. Now you switch to trumps.

The way you decide whether to start pulling trumps right away is to use your imagination.

Imagine what the defense will do if you lead a round of trumps. Then imagine what they will do if you play a different suit instead.

**Board 3**

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 5 2  
♥ Q J T 8 4  
♦ K 9  
♣ J 8 6 3

♠ A 6 3  
♥ 7 5 2  
♦ A 7 5 3  
♣ T 5 4



♠ K T 9 8  
♥ 9 6 3  
♦ Q J 4  
♣ 9 7 2

♠ Q J 7 4  
♥ A K  
♦ T 8 6 2  
♣ A K Q

| West     | North | East | South |
|----------|-------|------|-------|
| Pass     | 2♦    | Pass | 1♦    |
| All Pass |       |      | 3NT   |

3NT by South

This is one of the most misplayed positions in bridge. The usual approach is to lead the ♠Q, hoping that West holds the ♠K. But this can't succeed. If West does hold the ♠K he will cover, either this trick or the ♠J, and someone's ♠T will become a winner. Of course if East has the ♠K then the finesse will fail, along with your chance of 2 more winners.

The correct way to play for 2 more tricks is to hope **EAST** has the ♠K and lead twice toward your ♠Q J. So win the first trick, play ♠4 to dummy's ♠A. Lead the ♠3 toward your hand, playing the ♠J if East plays low. (Of course if East ever plays the ♠K he gives you two winners immediately.) When the ♠J wins, return to dummy with the ♦A and lead the ♠6 toward your ♠Q.

When East holds the ♠K you can always get 3 ♠ tricks if you play correctly.

With 19 points you are too strong to open 1NT so you open 1♦. Partner responds 2♦.

Perhaps you can make 5♦. But 9 tricks are easier than 11 so you bid 3NT. Notice that there was no reason to "show" your ♠ suit. If partner held 4 ♠s he would not have bid 2♦.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

**South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.**

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You can create one winner in ♦s if they split 3-2, but too late, the defense would have set up their ♥s. So you must get 2 more ♠ tricks.

**Board 4**

East Deals

Both Vul

♠ Q J 9 8 7 3

♥ K Q 6

♦ 7 2

♣ J 4

♠ A T 2

♥ T 8 4

♦ J T 9 3

♣ Q T 5

|   |   |   |
|---|---|---|
|   | N |   |
| W |   | E |
|   | S |   |

♠ 6 4

♥ A 7 3

♦ K Q 5 4

♣ A K 8 2

♠ K 5

♥ J 9 5 2

♦ A 8 6

♣ 9 7 6 3

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

4♠

All Pass

4♠ by West

♦10. Ruff it, lead a ♣ to dummy and lead the last ♠. If South plays the other high honor you play low. If South plays low you guess whether to play the ♠K, or ♠T. Your best play is to assume the two honors were split and play the ♠Q.

Leading twice toward the ♠ Q J gives you a guarantee on this layout because South held a doubleton high honor.

Now

Here North has taken your ♠J with the ♠A. When you again lead a small ♠ from dummy say that South plays the ♠5.

You might think that North is just as likely to have held an original doubleton ♠ A K as doubleton ♠ A 10, and that playing the ♠9 would be as good a play as ♠Q.

This is untrue for a very classy-named reason - **The Principle of Restricted Choice**. You may not even believe it when you read it, but it's mathematically sound. If North were dealt an original ♠ A K, he would have been just as likely to win with the ♠K as with the ♠A. The fact that he actually won the ♠A makes it less likely that he also holds the ♠K.

**HE WHO KNOWS, GOES** You **KNOW** your side has 26-28 points. You **KNOW** your side has 8 or more ♠s. You **GO** to 4♠.

West plays 4♠. North leads the ♦J.

**West plays 4♠. North leads the ♦J.**

Losers: ♠ 2/3 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 0 : Total = 3/4

You are definitely going to lose the ♦A and the ♠A K. Therefore you must plan to avoid losing a third ♠.

You should lead **UP TO** your honor cards. Cover the ♦J and lose to South's ♦A. Win his return (probably another ♦) in dummy. Lead a small ♠ to your ♠J.

North wins with an honor and probably plays the ♠A. If South plays the other high honor you play low. If South plays low you guess whether to play the ♠K, or ♠T. Your best play is to assume the two honors were split and play the ♠Q.